

Symbolism

Reacting against what they perceived as the superficiality of Realism and Impressionism, Symbolists abandoned direct, literal representations in favour of implication, suggestion, spirituality, the imagination and dreams, aiming to evoke certain feelings and moods. The loosely organized movement began in the late 19th century, as artists, writers and poets emphasized their emotions, intellect, ideas and subjectivity, exploring subjects such as love, death, sin or disease, and used visual metaphors to represent them. It aimed to unite the material and the spiritual world, or as poet Jean Moréas (1856–1910) wrote in his Symbolist Manifesto of 1886: ‘to clothe the idea in sensuous form’. Prominent Symbolist painters included Puvis de Chavannes (1824–98), Gustave Moreau (1826–98), Odilon Redon (1840–1916), Eugène Carrière (1849–1906) and Vilhelm Hammershøi (1864–1916). The movement began in France, but appeared almost concurrently in Russia, Belgium and Austria. Although comparatively short-lived, it exerted a strong influence on late-19th-century German art and on several 20th-century movements.



Moreau, *Thracian Girl Carrying the Head of Orpheus on his Lyre*, 1865